



Keith
Speaking
Academy

5 SIMPLE BUT EFFECTIVE

ENGLISH PRONUNCIATION HACKS

KEITH O'HARE



Helping you Become a Confident English Speaker



Many IELTS students lack confidence in their speaking skills.

The Keith Speaking Academy helps you develop your speaking skills so you can face the examiner with confidence and ace the IELTS test.

This PDF is one of many that Keith has developed to help you do this.

Keith has been working in international education for over 20 years as a teacher, teacher trainer, and education manager.

He has helped over 40,000 students prepare for their IELTS Speaking test with his online courses.

Contents

- **The Importance of Pronunciation**
- **How to Use this PDF and MP3**
- **The 5 Pronunciation Hacks**

- 1. Link Phrasal Verbs**
- 2. Use Word Stress**
- 3. Listen for Missing Sounds**
- 4. Use the Schwa**
- 5. Use Diphthongs**



The Importance of Pronunciation

I want to show you how to improve your English pronunciation in 3 weeks, with 5 simple but effective pronunciation hacks.

Pronunciation is so important and it can be embarrassing when native speakers don't understand you.

I discovered this when I walked into a French shop on my first visit to France, and asked for 2 loaves or bread. In French I had to say, 'Je veux deux baguettes. s'il vous plaît!'

My pronunciation was so bad that the shop assistant had no idea what I was saying. How embarrassing!

The trouble is, I learnt French at school where we rarely practiced speaking, let alone pronunciation.

But pronunciation is a **key part** of communication, and if your pronunciation is not clear, communication breaks down.

If you haven't studied and practiced a lot of English pronunciation, this area may also be a challenge for you.

On top of that, English pronunciation may be the hardest thing to change, because you have been speaking the way you speak for so many years.

How to Use this PDF and MP3

So how do you change and improve your English pronunciation?

In this PDF (with MP3), I will show you a simple way to do it.

1. **Focus** on 5 key pronunciation features
2. **Repeat** 10 minutes everyday for 3 weeks
3. **Extend** to wider language

I will focus on 5 key pronunciation features in this PDF.

All you need to do is,

- Read this PDF and if possible watch the complete video too, here: [\(insert the link\)](#)
- For each pronunciation feature, follow the exercises, repeating the sounds on the MP3.
- Do this same activity, taking about 10 minutes, everyday for 3 weeks.

After 3 weeks, you will start to notice an improvement and you can start to extend these ideas to new examples and phrases.

THE 5 PRONUNCIATION HACKS



1. Link Phrasal Verbs

A **phrasal verb** is a verb plus a preposition or an adverbial particle.

For example,

To **look up**

- *I look up a new word in the dictionary*

Linking is an important pronunciation feature in English, especially for IELTS Speaking, and basically means, connecting 2 words by saying them as one sound.

So 'look up', (as two words) becomes 'lookup' (one sound).

We can link, when a word ends in a consonant and the next word begins with a vowel sound.

The trick is to move the final consonant sound of the first word, to the beginning of the second word.

- *Look**k** up*
- *Loo → **k**up*

Let's see some more examples.

How do you pronounce these?

- *Get off*
- *Take out*
- *Clear up*

You could say them as individual words, but native speakers would tend to link them, saying them as one sound.

If you linked them how would they sound?

- *Get_off*
- *Take_out*
- *Clear_up*

Let's find out.

Now play the MP3, listen and repeat the examples below.

WARNING:

Do not read the examples below as you do this!

Play the MP3 without reading, and use your ears to really hear and then repeat the sounds.

Phrasal Verb	Example
Get off	Get off the train
Take out	Take out the rubbish
Clear up	Clear up this mess
Get on	Get on the bus
Get over	I have got over my cold
Get up	What time do you usually get up?
Take off	The plane is taking off soon
Give away	He wants to give away all his money
Put on	It's warm today, so I don't know what clothes to put on
Turn on	Can you turn on the TV, please?
Make up	Do you usually like to make up for work?
Look after	I can look after your cat when you are on holiday

2. Use Word Stress

In English, each word has a certain number of syllables

For example the word 'Beautiful', has 3 syllables or sounds.

Beau - ti - ful
1 2 3

Every word has one syllable that is stressed more than the others.

However, many students put equal stress on each syllable. This makes their English sound boring and 'un-English'!

Look at where the syllables should be stressed below (in **bold**)

- It's beautiful
- It's **beau** - ti - ful
- It's important
- It's im - **por** - tant
- This afternoon
- This af - ter - **noon**

How do you know which syllable to stress?

- 1. Listen carefully to spoken English and notice the stress.**
- 2. Use a dictionary**

Note: When we stress a syllable we often

- Make it longer
- Raise the pitch
- Increase the volume

Now play the MP3, listen and repeat the examples below.

Tip: Over-exaggerate the stress in each word when you practice.

Word with Stress on first syllable	Example
D ifficult	It's difficult for me
S aturday	I will go on Saturday
C omplicated	This is too complicated
B eautiful	You look beautiful
H ospital	Where is the nearest hospital?
F inally	Finally, you've arrived!
Y esterday	What did you do yesterday?

Basketball	Do you like playing basketball?
Swimming	Do you like swimming?
Produce (n.) = Fresh food	You can buy good, local produce in this market
Present (n.) = a gift	I want to give you a present
Conflict (n.) = a dispute	This conflict is causing a lot of problems for the government

Word with Stress on second syllable	Example
Im port ant	Listen, this is really important
To mor row	What are you doing tomorrow?
Be gin	What time does the meeting begin?
Ag ree	Do you agree with him?
Be fore	Before you get angry, listen to me!
To wards	We are heading towards the city centre
Pro duce (v) = to make	What does your company produce?
Pre sent (v.) = to give	They presented me with a prize
Con flikt (v.) = to differ	Your story conflicts with hers!

Word with Stress on third syllable	Example
Every day	I jog everyday
Disa gree	I totally disagree
After noon	Let's meet tomorrow afternoon
Under stand	I don't understand it
Recomm end	I highly recommend this book
Recol lect	I can't recollect what I did yesterday
Intro duce	Let me introduce myself
Guarant ee	I can guarantee it will work
Convers ation	This is an interesting conversation

3. Listen for Missing Sounds

In spoken English, we sometimes drop sounds that are written, but difficult to pronounce.

We call this 'elision'.

Let's take an example; how do you pronounce this?

- **I can't go**

Normally, a native speaker would not pronounce the /t/ sound.

They would say it like this

/aɪ kɑ:n gəʊ/

The 't' sound is dropped.

The most common elisions are with /t/ and /d/ sounds, normally when they are between consonants.

So in our example, you can see the /t/ is between /n/ and /g/

- **I can't go**

I mean try pronouncing /ntg/!

It's not easy, and native speakers want to make life easier, so we drop the /t/ sound.

Simple!

Let's look at two common words now, and later you can extend this pronunciation to other words and examples.

1. MUST

- *You must see this*

Here the /t/ is between /s/ and another /s/
So, we drop the /t/ sound.

We would say,

/jʊ mʌs si: ðɪs/

2. NEXT

- *Next week*

Here the /t/ is between /x/ and /w/
So, we drop the /t/ sound.

We would usually say,

/nɛks wi:k/

- *Next time*

Here the /t/ is between /x/ and another /t/
So, we drop the first /t/ sound.

We would usually say,

/nɛks taɪm/

Now play the MP3, listen and repeat the examples below.

Elision	Example
Can't go	I can't go to the party
Must see	You must see this film, it's great
Must go	It's late, I must go!
Next week	Are you free next week?
Next time	I will take you to the cinema next time
Last night	I went out last night
Iced Tea	Do you want some iced tea?
Let me	Let me help you with that
Cooked dinner	She cooked dinner for me last night
Watched TV	I watched TV yesterday

4. Use the Schwa

How do you pronounce these?

- *To*
- *For*
- *Do*
- *You*
- *And*

Many small words like this, actually have a strong and a weak form.

The strong form is pronounced as you would probably read the word above, and it is used when the word is **stressed**.

However, 90% of the time, these words are **unstressed**.

In this case, we use the **weak form**, usually using the Schwa sound /ə/.

- /tə/
- /fə/
- /də/
- /jə/
- /ən/

There are a small number of short words that have a weak forms, and those are mainly, prepositions, verbs and auxiliaries, personal pronouns and conjunctions.

Let's look at some examples with the words above.

- **It's ten to two**

Notice 'ten' and 'two' are stressed and 'to' is unstressed so it is pronounced /tə/

- **It's for you**

Notice 'it's' and 'you' are stressed and 'for' is unstressed so it is pronounced /fə/

- **Do you like it?**

Notice 'like' is stressed and 'do' and 'you' are unstressed so they are pronounced /də/ and /jə/

- **Fish and chips**

Notice 'fish' and 'chips' are stressed and 'and' is unstressed so it is pronounced /ən/. Also the /d/ is dropped due to the elision mentioned above.

Now play the MP3, listen and repeat the examples below.

Word	Weak form	Example
To	/tə/	It's ten to four, we must go!
		Give it to him!
For	/fə/	This is for her
		This present is for you
Do	/də/	Do you want it?
		Do you like it?
Can	/kən/	Can you help me?
		I can speak English
And	/ən/	Neat and tidy
		He is cool, calm and collected
She	/ʃi/	She's leaving tomorrow
		She'll go with you to the party
You	/jə/	You can go to class everyday
		Where do you live?

5. Use Diphthongs

In English we have different kinds of vowels; short, long and diphthongs.

The latter, diphthongs, are vowels where the speaker slides from one short vowel sound to another.

These are difficult for many students because, either they don't have diphthongs in their mother tongue and / or the short vowels are also different in their own language.

There are 8 diphthongs in English.

Here are 3 with some examples.

1. The 'O' sound /əʊ/

This can be represented in spelling in many ways such as,

- 'o' - go, so, no
- 'ow' - know, tow, low
- 'oe' - foe, toe
- 'ew' - sew
- 'ough' - though

This sound is made by sliding from the /ə/ sound towards the /ʊ/ sound and finishing with your lips in a round shape.

The important thing with this diphthong is not the length. Some students over-exaggerate this, trying to sound 'British'. Actually it's the rounding of the lips at the end that is important.

2. The 'Ay' sound /eɪ/

This can be represented in spelling in many ways such as,

- 'ay' - day, say, may
- 'ey' - they
- 'ea' - great,
- 'a + consonant + e' - cake, take, make
- 'eigh' - weigh, eight

This sound is made by sliding from the /e/ sound (as in **be**d) towards /ɪ/ (as in **ch**ip). Your mouth will start half-open and finish with your lips slightly open in a gentle smile.

3. The 'I' sound /aɪ/

This can be represented in spelling in different ways such as,

- 'i' - Hi, tie, lie
- 'y' - my, try, cry

This sound is made by sliding from the /a/ sound (as in **cat**) towards /ɪ/ (as in **chip**). Your mouth will start open and finish with your lips slightly open in a gentle smile.

Now play the MP3, listen and repeat the examples below.

Word	IPA	Example
Go	/gəʊ/	Shall we go?
So	/səʊ/	So, let me know if you agree
Know	/nəʊ/	Do you know where it is?
No	/nəʊ/	There is no way this will work
Day	/deɪ/	Which day works for you?
Say	/seɪ/	What do you want to say?
May	/meɪ/	It may be a good idea
Hi	/haɪ/	Hi, what's your name?
My	/maɪ/	According to my phone, it's six o'clock
Lie	/laɪ/	Don't lie to me!
Eye	/aɪ/	We don't see eye to eye

Remember, repeat these exercises for the 5 pronunciation features, everyday over 3 weeks.

You will notice an improvement. Good luck and keep practicing!

Want more help with your Pronunciation?

If accurate pronunciation is a challenge for you, especially in longer conversations, then I can help.

In addition to these 5 pronunciation hacks, I have an **online course** that will **improve your intonation** and overall pronunciation, making you feel much more confident in conversations.

Fluent Grammar for IELTS Speaking.

It focuses on the most common grammatical tenses in everyday conversations, and helps you perfect natural, English intonation for each one.

It's simple, just buy the course, practice regularly, and feel your confidence grow as your pronunciation gets better and better.

Unclear pronunciation causes confusion and breakdowns in communication, so make sure that doesn't happen to you.

With this course, you will become a more confident speaker with clear pronunciation.

Click below to get the course **Fluent Grammar for IELTS Speaking** and get an extra **10% off!**

WWW.KEITHSPEAKINGACADEMY.COM

